

Collapsing Flat Waves

Robert Rehnig
24 Sept – 14 Okt

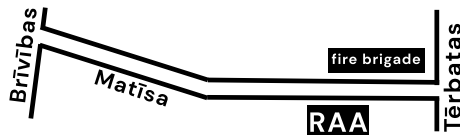
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Hochschule für Musik FRANZ LISZT Weimar
Bauhaus-Universität Weimar

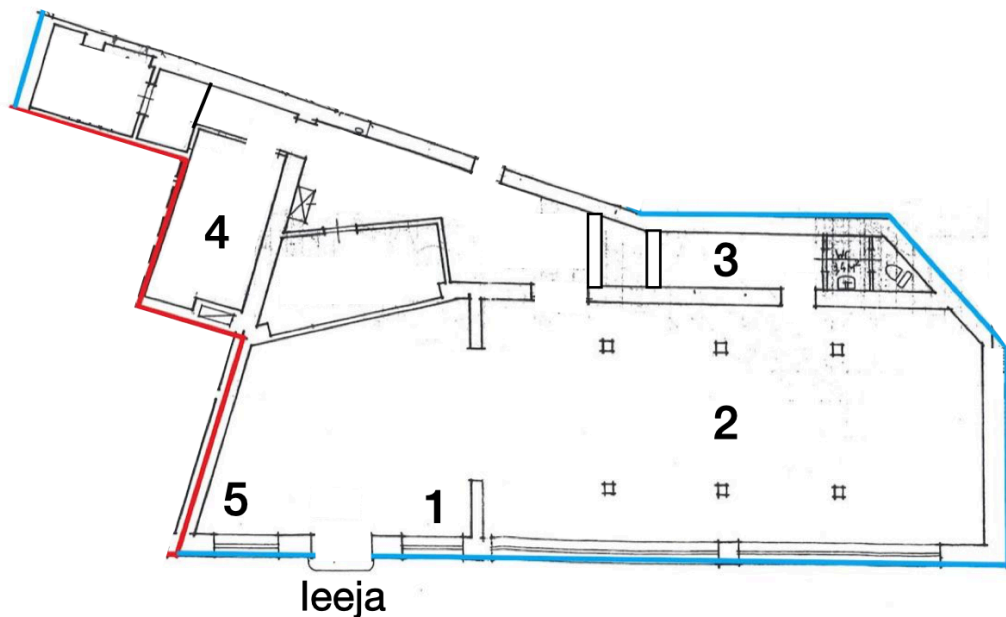


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Robert Rehnig's works often explore simplified, perceptible processes that take the form of abstract soundscapes. The exhibition features installations that focus in particular on the perception of space and, in a broader sense, on silence. The common theme is always the transition from hearing to listening.



Robert Rehnig (born 1977) is a Leipzig-based sound artist and composer. He works in the fields of audio books, music for stage plays and sound installation art. His series "Souvenirs entomologiques" was awarded the German Audio Book Award. His works have been presented at (selection): Singuhr-Hörgalerie Berlin, Festspielhaus Hellerau Dresden, Kunstverein Hamburg, ZixP-Festival Leipzig, Mid-Autumn Harvest Moon Festival Montréal, Maison du Géant Salins-les-Bains, Patarei Tallinn, Festival Punto de Encuentro Valencia, sound:frame-Festival Künstlerhaus Vienna and Frühjahrstage für zeitgenössische Musik Weimar. He teaches at SeaM (Studio for Electroacoustic Music and Sound Art, University of Music "Franz Liszt" Weimar) and at the electronic music studio of the University of Music and Theatre "Felix Mendelssohn Bartholdy" Leipzig. He is currently a PhD candidate at the Bauhaus-Universität Weimar, researching the psychophysics and phenomenology of silence.

1 Collapsing Flat Waves – This work is a visual invitation to the exhibition and reveals its tiny sounds when you enter the gallery. The real world waves of the Baltic Sea are digitalized and flattened to 2D on a screen laying in the window. The sound is transformed to synthetic tiny clicks which represent in their density the loudness of the audio track of the recorded video. Beyond that, except of those artifacts, the acoustical waveform remains flat, too.

2 Calm Down But Keep Breathing – This reactive spatial sound installation represents an acoustically breathing gallery room – or a fictional, abstract creature. In the illuminated centre of the space, a loudspeaker chassis installed to the ceiling, builds a kind of column within which the intracorporal sound of inhaled air is audible, while fifteen loudspeaker chassis mounted on the walls project the sound of exhaled air, spreading through an imaginary larger building. The measured loudness of the gallery's inside and outside environment influences this acoustic creature and lets it react by temporarily falling quiet.

3 Traces in a pond – In a small corridor of the gallery eight speakers and a microphone build a simple kind of ecosystem of slowly beating sinus waves. If the visitors or listeners do not behave quiet the oscillation becomes more excited and calms down as soon as silence is rebuilt again.

4 Dissociative Whispering Machine – A mysterious black box, reminiscent of a hybrid between a loudspeaker and an anglerfish, is positioned in the middle of a dark room. It speaks very quietly and completely incomprehensibly as long as visitors only listen and remain silent. As soon as they start to talk themselves, the machine sharpens its pronunciation and forms meaningful sentences – which are not so easy to understand, since one is speaking at the same time. Once the listener falls quiet again, the machine returns to its gibberish.

5 Phonographies – Two soundscape recordings from the Pennine Alps in Switzerland. One is a small aircraft flying through the wind still silence at the height of the four thousand meter peaks. Recorded under the peak of the Lagginhorn. The other is a recording within the town of Saas-Fee during a gathering thunder storm.